Plan here

Google Maps

Trips 2.0

The story of Google Trips

Google Trips was a comprehensive travel planning and exploration app designed to streamline the trip organization, offer personalized recommendations, and enhance the travel experience for users.

Launched in	Lifetime downloads	Discontinued in
2016	5 Milllion	2019

Reasons behind launching Trips

- **Increased user engagement** and retention within Google's ecosystem.
- **Valuable data collection** on travel preferences, aiding in improving offerings and advertising targeting.
- **Monetization opportunities** through partnerships and sponsored content.
- Competitive differentiation and strengthening of **Google's presence in the travel industry.**
- **Seamless integration with other services**, enhancing user convenience and cross-platform usage.

The offerings from Trips

- **Centralized Planning**: Streamlined trip planning with all travel essentials in one app.
- **Personalized Itineraries:** Custom recommendations based on user data and preferences.
- **Offline Access & Real-Time Updates:** Download trip details for offline use and receive real-time destination information.
- **Seamless Integration & User-Friendly:** Integrated with Google accounts, easy navigation for all travelers.

The end of Trips

- **Google Maps Integration:** Google Trips features were integrated into Google Maps, streamlining the travel experience within a single app.
- **Resource Allocation:** Google may have allocated resources to other strategic projects, resulting in the discontinuation of Google Trips.
- **Unified User Experience:** The integration aimed to offer users a comprehensive travel planning and exploration platform in one app.

Rebooting Google Trips on Maps

Why Google will be interested in a reboot?

Making a case for the reboot

- **The booming travel industry:** The global travel market will be $8.9T by 2026. The post-covid era has catapulted the industry.
- **User engagement:** Consolidating user focus in one place will bring meaningful engagement which will lead to better ad recommendations.
- **Monetization opportunities:** A growth in user engagement will bring the opportunity to push more monetization by leveraging the data being generated.

Why add it to Google Maps?

Maps has the popularity and functionalities

- **Navigation and Directions:** It offers detailed navigation.
- **Local Recommendations:** "Explore nearby" provides personalized recommendations for restaurants, attractions, and hotels.
- **Integration and Convenience:** Google Maps integrates with reservations, offers offline maps, and allows users to share their location, making it a comprehensive and convenient travel companion.
- **Popularity:** Google Maps is easily among the most popular applications out there.

What went wrong with Trips?

Mistake to avoid

- **Standalone app:** A dedicated app led to user fragmentation, redundancy with existing Google services, and lower user engagement compared to more established apps.
- **Not enough marketing:** Insufficient marketing led to Google Trips' limited success, despite positive user feedback. The more extensive promotion was needed to increase its user base.

Optimal Product Focus

Which segment should be targeted?

Group Traveler

- **Organization Enthusiast:** Seeking tools to streamline coordination for transportation, reservations, and accommodations, making group travel planning more efficient.
- **Inclusivity Advocate:** Desiring solutions to ensure everyone feels included and engaged, fostering a sense of togetherness during group trips.
- **Flexibility Seeker:** In need of ways to navigate diverse interests and schedules, allowing for a balanced and fulfilling travel experience.
- **Budget-conscious Traveler:** Looking for methods to manage cost-sharing seamlessly.
- **Collaborative Decision-seeker:** Longing for tools that facilitate group decision-making, making it easier to reach satisfying consensuses and harmonious travel plans.

They will bring more engagement

User Persona

Sarah Bailey | 24yrs | Residing in Canton, US | Marketing Manager

Background:
Sarah enjoys taking time off from her demanding job to explore new destinations with her close-knit group of friends. They have known each other since college and have been traveling together for over a decade.

Pain Points:
Sarah acknowledges that decision-making can be challenging, with varying interests and opinions sometimes leading to delays or compromises. She finds it challenging to strike the right balance between accommodating individual preferences and ensuring the group's overall satisfaction.

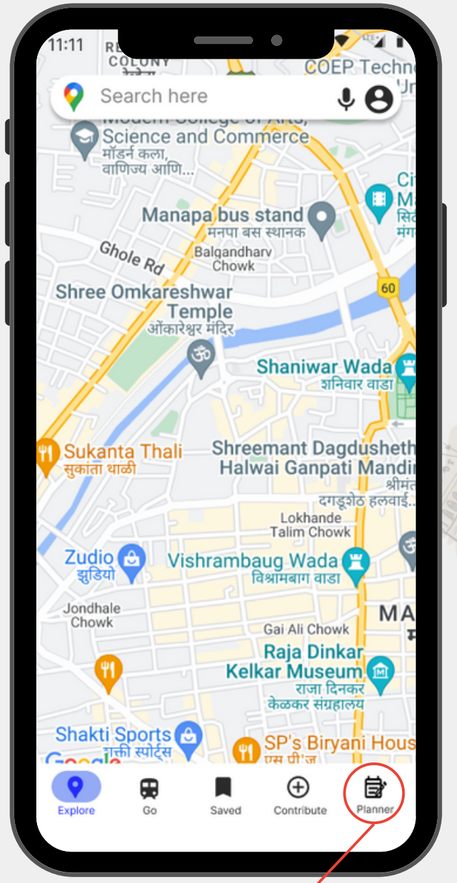
Goals and Expectations:
Sarah aims to discover a travel platform that fosters inclusivity and strengthens group bonds. Additionally, she seeks a user-friendly tool to simplify logistics, decision-making, and coordination, ensuring a cohesive and enjoyable travel experience for her close-knit group.

Feature Highlights

Feature	Whats that?	Rationale behind it
Curators	Collaborative Travel Planning - effortlessly add fellow travelers and co-plan your adventures together for unforgettable journeys🌍✈️	Focusing on the target audience, letting a group collaborate to plan a trip will make the process more fulfilling and increase participation on the platform.
Surprise me	Destination Dilemma Solver! Let us pick the perfect destination for you when you're unsure. Say goodbye to indecision! 🗺️✨	When planning a trip, it can be difficult to choose a destination. Therefore, a tool to help users overcome this choice dilemma would be beneficial.
Buckets	The Travel Bucket Organizer! Easily save activities and destinations for future trips, seamlessly adding them to your travel plans. Plan hassle-free! 🗺️✨	Planning a trip can be a long task. Our feature allows users to save their preferred destinations and activities in one convenient location, ensuring that they don't overlook anything important while planning their trip.
Insights	Trip Planner Insights! Get real-time stats on top contributors and planning progress for collaborative travel experiences. Stay informed! 📊🗺️	This feature aims to encourage users to participate more in the process and gain an understanding of the amount of planning that remains.
Curators Poll	Travel Poll Creator! Collaboratively make informed decisions with fellow travelers through polls, ensuring everyone's input counts. 📋✨	This feature will make collaboration easier among the group and will ensure that everyone has a say in the plan.
InfoSync	Smart Travel Info Extractor! Effortlessly extract ticket and reservation details from your messages to auto-populate your travel plan. Organized travels made easy! 📧✈️	Borrowed from the Google Trips, it ensures important information like ticket numbers and reservations seamlessly integrates into their travel plans, promoting organization and efficiency.
gCurator	AI-Powered Itinerary! Let artificial intelligence create personalized travel recommendations, making planning a breeze. Effortless adventures await! 🤖✈️	This feature will provide a base upon which the users can build a plan.

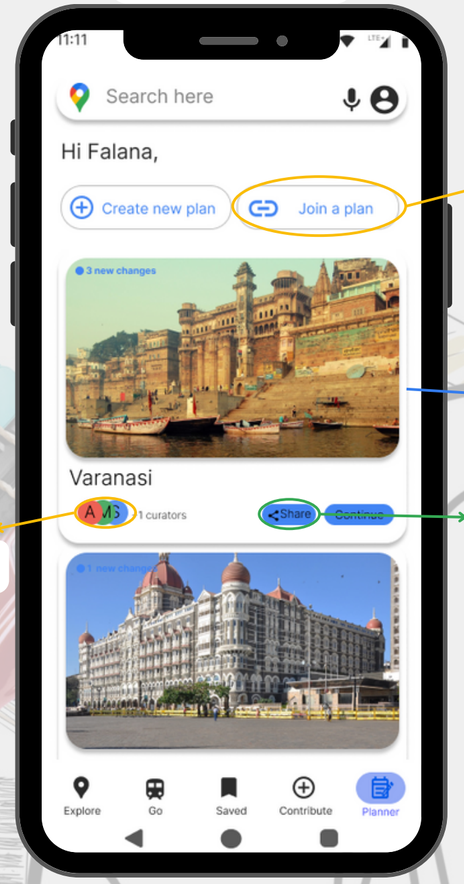
Prototype..

Maps



Travel Planner

Landing page of the feature



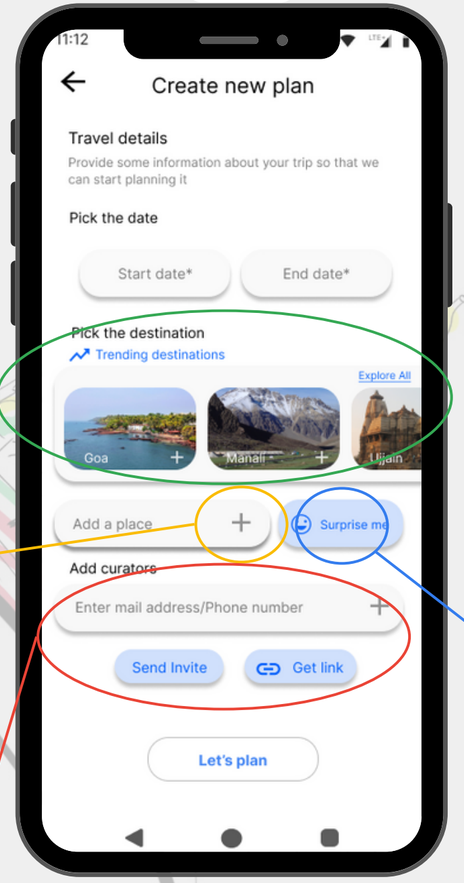
All the curators

User can join an existing trip being planned

Already on-going planning

Share the link with your group so they can start contributing

Creating new plan



These recommendations will be as per the season and public's preference.

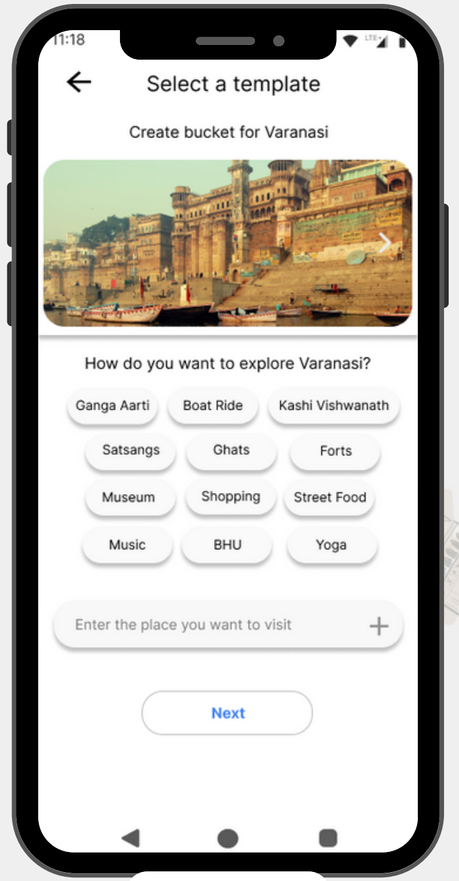
Users can manually add the destinations

Add your fellow travelers to the plan. You can directly send them invite via mail or share the link.

If users are not sure where they want to go, they may let Google to put a destination in their itinerary. The destination would appear on this screen and can be amended by the user here itself.

Prototype.

Creating buckets



Bucket

Users can add their preferences to a bucket here. Adding an activity to the bucket would let Google:

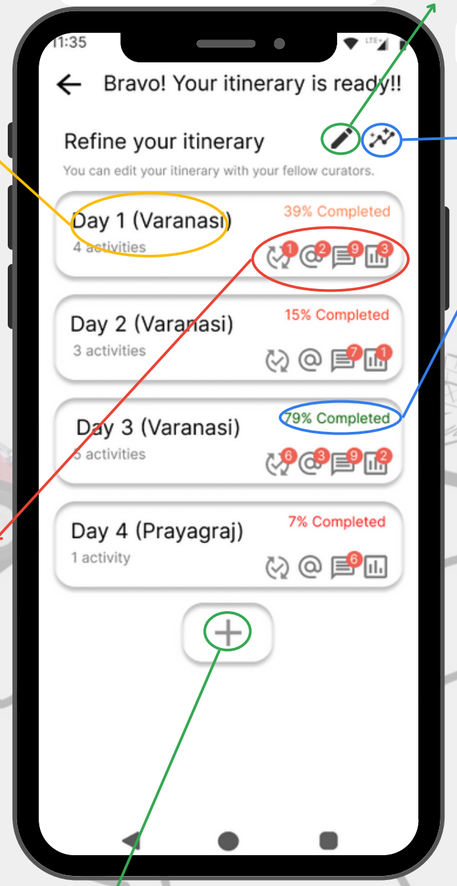
1. Add it to the itinerary
2. Recommend similar activities

Google's recommendation

Cards for the specific days. User can plan everything for the day here.

A quick insight to the on-going planning. This will include:

1. Changes - What all changes have been made?
2. Mentions - How many times your fellow travelers mentioned you.
3. Comment - New comments added to the discussions.
4. Poll - On-going polls



Users can add days to the itinerary

Users can edit the dates and destinations here.

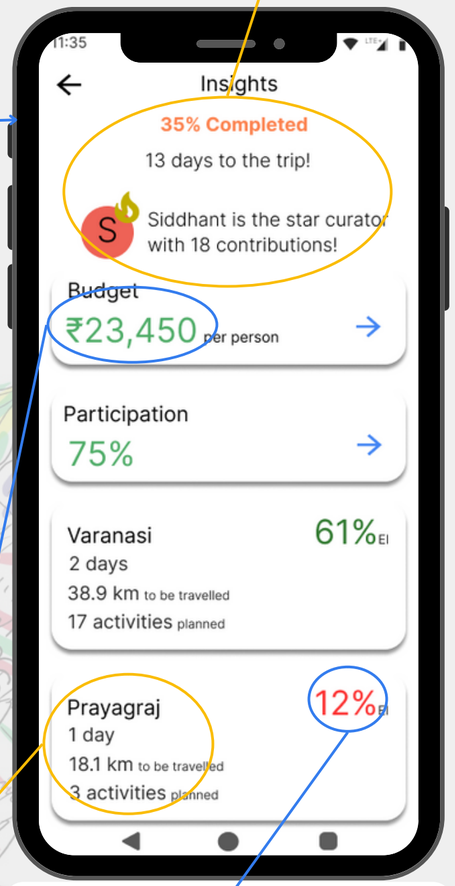
Insights

A number that signifies much planning of the day has been done. This will let user concentrate on the grey areas of the planning.

An estimated budget google shows by including the charges available to it. The per-person pricing has been used so its easy for a traveler to know his expenditure.

A card which shows all the numbers related to an individual destination.

1. The total completion percentage of the plan. This is to motivate users to complete the planning.
2. How many days are left for the trip? This is shown to create a sense of urgency to complete the plan.
3. The top contributor to the plan. This is shown to push the curators to contribute more.

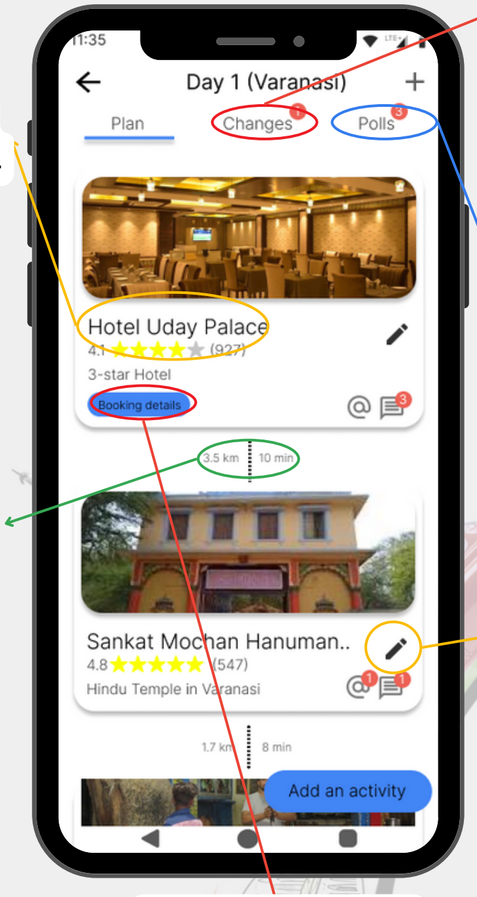


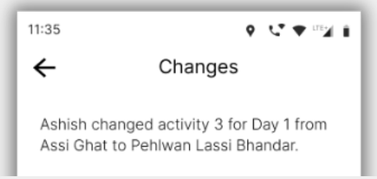
Exploration Index

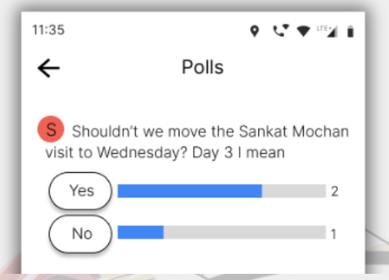
An index which lets users know how many of the popular activities they have added to their itinerary. The rationale behind this is that a user should not miss the core offerings of a destination.

Prototype

Planning a day







A card for the activity.

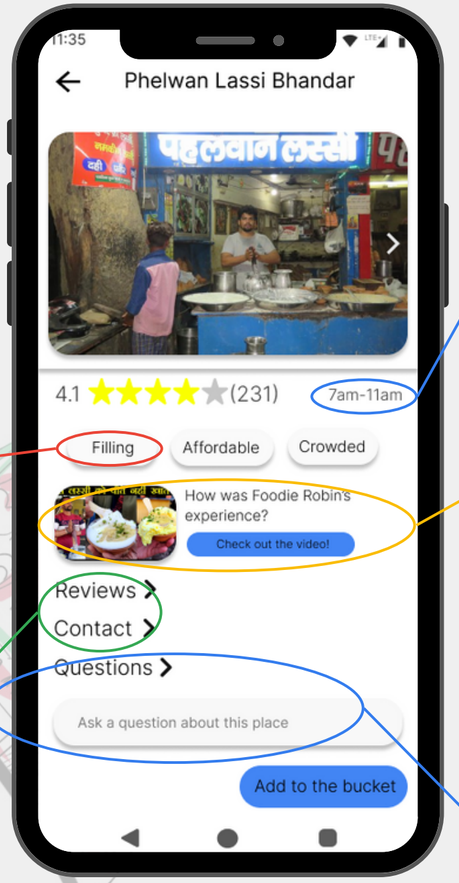
Get an idea of the commute time between two activities.

Change/Replace the activity

Documents

For the activities which need booking, users get an option to upload their documents here so that they can access it when required.

Adding an activity



Timing of the activity

A link to the vlogs available related to that activity

Most common tags from the reviews.

Reviews left by users and a option to contact the activity owner

Users can view the already asked questions and add new questions to be asked by other users or activity owners.

Check out the prototype on Figma

Metrics

Metric type:	Metric	Note
North Star	%Successfully planned trips ↑	A successfully planned trip is one where reservation documents are uploaded or extracted, OR more than 50% of the itinerary is planned.
Adoption	% MoM increase in users with at least one initiated/participated travel plan. ↑	A user who has participated in at least one travel plan will get a gist of the value being offered.
Engagement	• %Users actively collaborating ↑ • AVG (Planning duration/#Days planned) ↑	Users collaborating will bring the most engagement over the platform.
Performance	• %Promoted/Suggested activities included ↑ • AVG (%Itinerary planned) ↑	Users efficiently planning their itineraries ensures that the value is being provided.
Revenue	Ad-impressions ↑ and CTR ↑	To determine if the product is fulfilling the business outcome or not.
Retention	%(#Returning users/#Unique Users) ↑	To check if the users who have already realized the value, are continuing to use it or not.
System	• %Time product is available and up ↑ • %Error Rate ↓	To determine if the users are able to access and use the product smoothly.
Satisfaction	CSAT ↑	To measure the satisfaction of users

Second order thinking

Why Google hasn't done it already?

1. **Google is already providing value** to its users through other travel-related offerings.
2. There are a good number of other products which provide curated itineraries for travelers. Google might not want to jump into a **space that is already populated with competitors.**
3. Google is known for experimenting with new products. Since they have already given Trips a chance, they might be **directing their resources elsewhere.**
4. Google didn't have a great experience with Trips. It might not want to delve into something which is **tested and rejected.**

What may go wrong here?

1. Users may find the whole process bit tiresome as it is long and requires commitment.

Mitigation: An AI chatbot can be added to assist the user at each step and provide apt recommendations.

2. Estimating the budget will be very tricky. This may hamper the authenticity of the platform.

Mitigation: The activity owners can be prompted to update the details on Google. An updated activity may rank higher than others.